Assured Destruction (SAD).[8] A 'Nuclear Winter' would have been (and could still be) the ultimate act of human-made climate change.

The evidence suggests that a similar fate befell the dinosaurs sixty-five million years ago, when an asteroid struck the earth near Chicxulub, in what is now Mexico. The dinosaurs existed for 165 million years. Humankind – *homo sapiens* – is believed to have emerged some 200,000 years ago. Nuclear weapons were created less than eighty years ago. We cannot predict when (or whether) an asteroid as large (or larger) than the one that struck near Chicxulub will collide with Planet Earth. Nor can we predict if, or when, humanity's extinction will be precipitated by thermonuclear war.

There are those, however, who believe we can make predictions about the possibility of nuclear war. Thirty years after the crisis, Robert McNamara observed:

> Human beings are fallible. We know we all make mistakes. In our daily lives, mistakes are costly, but we try to learn from them. In conventional war, they cost lives, sometimes thousands of lives. But if mistakes were to affect decisions relating to the use of nuclear forces, there would be no learning period. They would result in the destruction of nations. I believe, therefore, it can be predicted with confidence that the indefinite combination of human fallibility and nuclear weapons carries a very high risk of a potential nuclear catastrophe.[9]

Imagining the past

During the 1950s anxiety about the global impact of radioactive fallout and continuing Cold War tension led to growing political opposition to nuclear weapons. Fiction also provided an accessible means of thinking about the unthinkable. In 1957, for example, Nevil Shute published *On the Beach*, a novel that portrayed the end of humankind in the aftermath of nuclear war.[10] In 1959 the book was made into an internationally acclaimed film (starring Gregory Peck, Ava Gardner, and Fred Astaire).[11] And in 1964 Stanley Kubrick's black comedy, *Dr Strangelove*, became one of the most